After I Was Thrown in the River and Before I Drowned

By Dave Eggers

UN-NAMED PIT BULL: OH I'M A FAST DOG. I'm fast- fast. It's true and I love being fast I admit It I love it. You know fast dogs. Dogs that just run by and you say, That's a fast dog! Well that's me. A fast dog. I'm a fast- fast dog. H*ooooooooo*! *Hooooooooooooo*!

INTRODUCTION

Pit Bulls are probably the most abused dogs on the planet. The breed suffers horribly at the hand of humans. In the face of potential and outright banning of this breed, the dogs--very real victims--are often completely overlooked.

Case #5125 . . . Severely dehydrated, starved and beaten with a metal pipe. This pit bull was barely clinging to life after losing a fight and being bagged and thrown in the river to die by its former owner. But fate intervened and this pup was found in the nick of time. This is where our story begins

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PIT BULL: I love it I love it. I run to feel the cool air cool through my fur. I run to feel the cold water come from my eyes. I run to feel my jaw slacken and my tongue come loose and flap from the side of my mouth and I go and go and go my name is Steven.

I was once in a river. I was thrown in a river when I was small. You just cannot know. I was swimming, trying to know why I had been thrown in the river. I was six months old, and my eyes were burning, the water was bad. I paddled and it was like begging. The land on either side was a black stripe, indifferent. I saw the gray water and then the darker water below and then my legs wouldn't work, were

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stuck in some kind of seaweed or spider web and then I was in the air. I opened my burning eyes and saw him in yellow. The fisherman. I was lifted from the water, the water was below me. Then shivering on their white plastic boat bottom and they looked at me with their mustaches. I dried in the sun. They brought me to the place with the cages and I yelled for days. Others were yelling too.

Everyone was crazy. Then people and a car and I was new at home. Ate and slept and it was dry, walls of wood. Two people and two girls, thin twins who sleep in the next room, with a dollhouse between them.

Every night I walk from the neighborhood and head to the woods and meet the others. It's shadowy out, the clouds low. I see the blues jumping inside the windows. I want all these people gone from the buildings and moved to the desert so we can fill the buildings with water. It's an idea I have. The buildings would be good if filled with water, or under water.

These people. The only ones I like are the kids. I come to the kids and lick the kids. I run to them and push my nose into their stomachs. I run around them and around again as they run forward. They're slow but they are perfect things, almost perfect.

I just cannot tell you how much I love all this, these woods, the dirt, and the smell of dogs nearby waiting to run. Tonight is cool, almost cold. There are no stars or clouds. We're all-impotent but there is running. I jog down the trail and see the others. Six of them tonight-Edward, Franklin, Susan, Mary, Robert, and Victoria.

Tonight I race Edward. Edward is a bull terrier and he is fast and strong but his eyes want to win too much; he scares us. The course is a simple one. We run from the entrance through the black-dark interior and out to the meadow and across the meadow and into the next woods, along the creek, then over the gap over the

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drainpipe and then along the creek until the highway. The jump over the drainpipe is the hard part. On the banks of the creek, near the drainpipe, on the dirt and in the weeds and on the branches of the rough gray trees are the squirrels. The squirrels have things to say; they talk before and after we jump. Sometimes while we're jumping they talk.

SQUIRREL 1: He is running funny.

SQUIRREL 2: She will not make it across.

PIT BULL: When we do not make it across the gap, and instead fall into the sandy bank, the squirrels say other things, their eyes full of glee.

SQUIRREL 1: It makes me laugh that she did not make it across the gap.

SQUIRREL 2: I am very happy that he fell and seems to be in pain.

PIT BULL: Sometimes one of the dogs, annoyed past tolerance, catches a squirrel in his mouth and crushes him. But then the next night they are back, all the squirrels, more of them. Always more.

Edward is nudging me as I run. He bites me and bumps me and yells things at me. When we come to the bend he tries to bump me into the tree. I skid and then find my footing and keep running. I catch up to him quickly and because I am faster I gain all the speed and then I see the gap. Two more strides and I jump.

I clear the gap by two feet and turn to see Edward jumping, and Edward's face looking across the gap, looking at my side of the gap, and his eyes still on the grass, exploding for it, and then he is falling, and only his front paws, claws, land above the bank. He yells something as he grabs, his eyes trying to pull the rest of him up, but he slides down the bank. He is fine but in the past others have been hurt. One dog, Wolfgang, died here, years ago. The other dogs and I jump down to help Edward up. The squirrels say things.

SQUIRREL 1: That was a terrible jump.

SQUIRREL 2: Bad landing. . . . Awful landing.

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PIT BULL: I run the rest of the race alone. After we all run we go home. The next night I walk alone to the woods, my claws clicking on the sandpaper cement.

Tonight I race Susan. Susan is a retriever, a small one, fast and pretty with black eyes. We take off, through the entrance through the black-dark interior and out to the meadow. Then the straightaway before the gap. Now we have to think about our own legs and muscles and timing before the jump. Susan looks at me and smiles but looks tired. Two more strides and I jump and then the hard ground rushes toward me and I land and hear her scream. I turn to see her face failing down the gap and run back to the gap. Robert and Victoria are down with her already. Her leg is broken and bleeding from the joint. She screams then wails, knowing everything already. The squirrels are above and talking.

SQUIRREL 1: Well, looks like she got what she deserved.

SQUIRREL 2: That's what you get when you jump.

PIT BULL: Some of them laugh. Franklin is angry. He walks slowly to where they're sitting; they do not move. He grabs one in his jaws and crushes all its bones. Their voices are always talking but we forget they are so small, their head and bones so tiny. The rest run away. He tosses the squirrel's broken form into the slow water.

We go home. I jog to the buildings with Susan on my back. I take her home and scratch at her door until she is let in. I go home and see the thin twins with their dollhouse and I go to the room with the bed and fall asleep before they come.

The next night I don't want to go to the woods. I can't see someone fall, and can't hear the squirrels, and don't want Franklin to crush them in his jaws. I stay at home and I play with the twins in their pajamas. They put me on a pillowcase and pull me through the halls. I like the speed and they giggle. I stay with them tonight and then stay home for days.

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When I come to the woods again, after ten days away, Susan has lost her leg. Susan has three legs, a bandage around her front shoulder. Her smile is a new and more fragile thing. It's colder out and the wind is mean and searching. Mary says that the rain has made the creek swell and the current too fast. The gap over the drainpipe is wider now so we decide that we will not jump.

I race Franklin. Franklin is still angry about Susan's leg; neither of us can believe that things like that happen, that she has lost a leg and now when she smiles she looks like she's asking to die. When we get to the straightaway I feel so strong that I know I will go. I'm not sure I can make it but I know I can go far, farther than I've jumped before. I want this so much, the floating.

I run and see the squirrels and their mouths are already forming the words they will say if I don't make it across. On the straightaway Franklin stops and yells to me that I should stop but it's just a few more strides and I've never felt so strong so I jump yes jump.

When I hit my head it was obvious. I hit my head and had a moment when I could still see - I saw Susan's face, her eyes open huge, and then the current took me out and then I fell under the surface. After I fell and was out of view the squirrels spoke.

SQUIRREL 1: He was a fool.

SQUIRREL 2: Everything he ever did was worthless.

PIT BULL: Franklin was angry and took five or six of them in his mouth, crushing them, tossing them one after the other. After I died, so many things happened that I did not expect. The first was that I was there, inside my body, for a long time. I was at the bottom of the river, stuck in a thicket of sticks and logs, for six days. I was dead, but was still there, and I could see out of my eyes. I could move around inside my body like it was a warm loose bag.

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I had been thrown into the river, a different river, when I was young by a man because I would not fight. I was supposed to fight and he kicked me and slapped my head and tried to make me mean. I didn't know why he was kicking me, slapping. I wanted him to be happy. I wanted the squirrels to jump and be happy as we dogs were. But they were different than we were, and the man who threw me to the river was also different. I thought we were all the same but as I was inside my dead body and looking into the murky river bottom I knew that some are wanting to run and some are afraid to run and maybe they are broken and are angry for it.

After the sixth day I woke up and it was bright. I knew I was back. I stood and was in a wide field of buttercups. I could smell their smell and walked through them, my eyes at the level of the yellow, a wide blur of a line of yellow.

I should say that it's very much the same here as there. There are more hills, and more waterfalls, and things are cleaner. I like it. Each day I walk for a long time, and I don't have to walk back. I can walk and walk, and when I am tired I can sleep. When I wake up, I can keep walking and I never miss where I started and have no home.

I haven't seen anyone yet. I don't miss the cement like sandpaper on my feet, or the buildings with the sleeping men reaching. I sometimes miss the other dogs and the running.

The one big surprise is that as it turns out. God is the sun. It makes sense, if you think about it. Why we didn't see it sooner I cannot say. Every day the sun was right there burning, our and other planets hovering around it, always apologizing, and we didn't think it was God. Why would there be a God and also a sun? Of course God is the sun. Everyone in the life before was cranky, I think, because they just wanted to know.

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